Indirect Realism

A workbook to use alongside the Indirect Realism slideshow. Work through it slide by slide, or use it on its own to revise.

This workbook follows the slideshow in order. Each part matches a group of slides. Read the short summary, then complete the tasks. If you miss a lesson, you can still work through it on your own: everything you need is in the boxes.

In this workbook

1. What is indirect realism? (slides 1–4)
2. The arguments for indirect realism (slide 5)
3. Objection 1: can we know there is an external world? (slides 6–9)
4. Locke's reasons for believing in the external world (slides 10–13)
5. Is a hypothesis enough? Moore's reply (slide 14)
6. Objection 2: the problem of representation (slides 15–17)
7. Exam practice: 5-mark questions
8. Revision summary and quick-check quiz

Part 01 What is indirect realism?

Indirect realism agrees with direct realism that there is a real, mind-independent world. It disagrees about how we perceive it. We do not perceive objects directly; we perceive sense-data, and the sense-data represent the world because the world causes them. The slideshow names John Locke and Bertrand Russell as its key defenders.

> Key Thesis
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> 1. Indirect: what we perceive immediately is sense-data – mental states that depend on a mind. We know them directly and privately. External objects are known only indirectly, by inference from sense-data.
> 2. Realism: external objects are real. They are mind-independent and go on existing when nobody perceives them.

Key idea Think of sense-data as the 'middle step' between you and the world: world → causes → sense-data → perceived by you.

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Sense-data	Mental states or information in the mind, caused by external objects, that represent those objects to us.
Mind-dependent	Depending on a mind for its existence.
Privileged access	Only I can be directly aware of my own sense-data, and I know them immediately.
Inference	Reaching a conclusion by reasoning from evidence, rather than by being directly aware of it.
External objects	Objects that exist outside the mind and can cause sense-data in the mind.

Task Fill in the gaps.

Indirect realism claims we perceive the world through _____. These are _____-dependent and we have _____ and private access to them. External objects can only be _____ from sense-data. The theory is 'realist' because it claims external objects exist _____ of the mind.

Task Explain the difference between direct and indirect realism in two or three sentences.

Part 02 The arguments for indirect realism

The arguments for indirect realism are the same four arguments you met against direct realism. Each one suggests that what we immediately perceive is not the object itself – so it must be something in the mind.

Task Complete the table, using Workbook 1 to help you.

Argument	How it supports indirect realism
Perceptual variation	
Illusion	

Hallucination	
Time lag	

Part 03 Objection 1: is there a world beyond sense-data?

Slide 6 gives two key objections to indirect realism. The first is sceptical. If all I am ever directly aware of is my own sense-data, how can I know that anything lies beyond them? I can never step outside my sense-data to check that an external world is causing them.

The argument in standard form

1. We are only ever immediately aware of sense-data.
2. We cannot check sense-data against the world, because any check gives us only more sense-data.
3. So we cannot know for certain that sense-data are caused by external objects.
4. Therefore indirect realism leads to scepticism about the external world.

Russell's response: the best hypothesis

Russell accepts that we cannot prove beyond doubt that external objects exist. But we can compare explanations. Either my sense-data are caused by my own mind, or by something like an evil demon, or they are caused by real objects outside the mind. The existence of an external world is the simplest and most plausible explanation, so it is rational to believe it.

1. Our sense-data need a cause.
2. Possible causes: my own mind; a deceiver such as an evil demon; real external objects.
3. The external-world hypothesis explains our experience best (it is simplest and most coherent).
4. Therefore it is rational to believe in the external world, even if it cannot be proved.

Key idea A best hypothesis is the best theory when more than one explanation is available. It gives reasonable belief, not certainty.

Task Why does Russell think the external world is a better hypothesis than an evil demon? Give one reason.

Part 04 Locke: why believe in physical objects?

Locke gives reasons for inferring that physical objects exist. Slide 13 sums them up in three points.

1. Sense-data are not under our control. With my eyes shut I can choose what to imagine, but when I open them I cannot choose what I see.
2. Our senses confirm one another. If I see a fire, I can go and feel its heat; if I hear a violin, I can go and see it.
3. Our actions and perceptions are related in complex, regular ways. What I experience changes in predictable ways when I act.

For Locke, sense-data are not simply products of the imagination: we cannot wish them away with our mind alone. This is good evidence that they come from something outside us.

Task Match each of Locke's three reasons to an example of your own.

Locke's reason	My own example
Not under our control	
Senses confirm each other	
Actions and perceptions linked	

Part 05 Is a hypothesis enough?

A critic can say that Locke and Russell only give us a hypothesis. On this view the external world is not merely the best guess; we know it is there. Slide 14 mentions G. E. Moore, who held up his hands, one after the other, and said that here was one hand and here was another, claiming this proved the existence of the external world.

Key idea Moore's point: we are more certain that we have hands than we could ever be of any sceptical argument against it.

Task Do you think Moore's 'proof' answers the sceptic? Give one reason for and one reason against.

Part 06 Objection 2: the problem of representation

The second objection asks how sense-data can represent the world at all. If sense-data are in the mind, they are probably chemical and biological events in the brain. But how can a biochemical event match up with, and stand for, a physical object such as a tree? They seem completely unalike.

The argument in standard form

1. For A to represent B, A must correspond to B in some way.
2. Sense-data are biochemical events in the brain.
3. Biochemical events in the brain seem nothing like physical objects in the world.
4. Therefore it is unclear how sense-data could represent the world.

A response: shared logical form (Wittgenstein)

Wittgenstein suggests that one thing can represent another without looking like it, if they share logical form – the same structure. The slideshow's example: a piece of music, its written score and the grooves on a record look nothing alike, yet each can be used to produce the others. In the same way, brain processes might represent the world by sharing its structure.

Key idea Wittgenstein is not a named thinker on the AQA specification for this topic, so treat this response as beyond the spec – useful for evaluation, but not required.

Task Using the music example, explain how something can represent another thing without resembling it.

Part 07 Exam practice: 5-mark questions

A 5-mark question tests AO1 only: knowledge and understanding. You do not need to evaluate. Aim for a precise, well-ordered explanation of about 150–200 words.

Model structure for a 5-mark answer

1. Define the key idea precisely in one sentence.
2. Set out the argument step by step (the premises and conclusion).
3. Use one clear example to show what you mean.
4. Finish by stating the conclusion and what it shows.

Task Explain indirect realism. (5 marks)

Task Explain the sceptical objection to indirect realism. (5 marks)

Task Explain Locke's reasons for believing that physical objects exist. (5 marks)

Task Explain the problem of representation for indirect realism. (5 marks)

Part 08 Revision summary and quiz

Revision summary

1. Indirect realism: we perceive a real, mind-independent world indirectly, through sense-data caused by it.
2. Arguments for: the four arguments against direct realism.
3. Objection 1 – scepticism: we cannot get beyond sense-data to check the world exists.
4. Responses: Russell's best hypothesis; Locke's three reasons (involuntary, senses agree, actions and perceptions linked).
5. Objection 2 – representation: how can brain events represent physical objects? Response: shared logical form (beyond the spec).

Quick-check quiz

1. What does indirect realism say we immediately perceive?
2. Why is the theory called 'realist'?
3. What does 'privileged access' mean?
4. What are the two key objections to indirect realism?
5. What is a 'best hypothesis'?
6. Give Locke's three reasons for believing in physical objects.
7. What did G. E. Moore do to 'prove' the external world?
8. What example illustrates shared logical form?

Answers (fold back or cover)

1. Sense-data.

2. It claims external objects are real and exist independently of the mind.
3. Only I can be directly aware of my sense-data, and I know them immediately.
4. Scepticism about the external world; the problem of representation.
5. The best theory when more than one explanation is available.
6. Sense-data are involuntary; our senses confirm each other; our actions and perceptions are linked.
7. Held up his hands in turn and said that here was one hand and here was another.
8. Music, its score and the grooves on a record.